

Research Designs

The overall strategy that links your question to your evidence

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

A research design is the overall plan for answering the research question — the logical structure that connects data collection and analysis to the aims. Common business designs include experiment, survey, case study, ethnography, action research, grounded theory and archival research. The design is chosen to fit the question and philosophy, not the other way round; it governs what data you gather, from whom, and how you will make sense of it (Yin, 2018).

FIXED / QUANTITATIVE DESIGNS

Experiment: manipulate a variable, measure effect under control.
Survey: standardised data from a sample to describe or find associations. Best when the concepts are well defined and you want breadth, comparison or generalisation.

FLEXIBLE / QUALITATIVE DESIGNS

Case study: in-depth study of one or few bounded cases.
Ethnography: immersion in a setting. Grounded theory: building theory from data. Action research: change and study a system together. Best for depth, process and context.

The design is a commitment, not a label. Saying 'this is a case study' obliges you to bound the case, justify its selection, and use multiple sources of evidence. Naming a design you do not actually follow through on is a frequent methodology weakness examiners identify quickly.

Design	Question it answers	Typical evidence
Experiment	Does X cause Y?	Controlled measurements
Survey	How much / how many / related?	Questionnaire data
Case study	How / why, in context?	Interviews, docs, observation
Grounded theory	What theory explains this?	Iterative interviews
Action research	How to improve this system?	Cycles of act-and-reflect

FIT, DON'T FOLLOW FASHION

Choose the design the question needs. A case study is not automatically 'deeper'; a survey is not automatically 'more rigorous'.

BOUND IT

Especially for case study: define what is inside and outside the case, and over what time frame. Ambiguous scope weakens claims.

MULTIPLE EVIDENCE

Case and ethnographic designs gain rigour from triangulating several data sources rather than relying on one.

Common pitfalls. (1) Naming a design but not following its requirements. (2) A single interview called a 'case study'. (3) A design that cannot answer the stated question. (4) Confusing the design (strategy) with the method (technique).

REFERENCES

Yin, R.K. (2018) *Case Study Research and Applications*. 6th edn. Thousand Oaks: SAGE. · Saunders, M., Lewis, P. and Thornhill, A. (2019) *Research Methods for Business Students*. 8th edn. Harlow: Pearson. · Creswell, J.W. and Creswell, J.D. (2018) *Research Design*. 5th edn. Thousand Oaks: SAGE.